

THE ERSTWHILE KANNADIGA ICON HAS FALLEN ON BAD DAYS

SINS OF THE FATHER

For his second stint as chief minister, which is expected to last much longer—considerably longer than the week-long tenure late last year—B.S. Yeddyurappa owes everything to one man and this man doesn't belong to his party. H.D. Deve Gowda was once a hero for the Kannadigas and also the only prime minister from the state. The election results from Karnataka last week seem to suggest that the icon has fallen on bad days, not trusted by his own people.

That the 76-year-old is getting increasingly paranoid and losing the common touch was evident on May 28 when, at his party office in Bangalore, he blamed the media for his party's pathetic poll performance and ordered them out, all the while hollering, "Get out all of you, get out right now or I will kick your ass." Unlike his immediate successor to the country's top job, I.K. Gujral, who is content chairing seminars and cutting ribbons, Gowda still harbours political ambitions, which has a lot to do with the fact that two of his sons have followed him into politics. After psephologists predicted another hung Assembly in the election, Gowda licked his lips in anticipation of becoming a king-maker again, but the shrewd electorate put paid to his plans.

The JD(S) is among the many splinter groups of the original Janata Dal led by V.P. Singh but is now only Karnataka-centric and revolves around Gowda and his two sons—former chief minister H.D. Kumaraswamy and

FALLEN: Deve Gowda (left) with sons Kumaraswamy (centre) and Revanna



B K RAMESH

committee to enable comprehensive planning for a contiguous region.

Chaos reigns on Bangalore roads, with about 700 vehicles added daily to the two million that already clog the city. A swanky new airport has come up in Devanahalli, 35 km from the city, but the approach roads to it are far from complete, making travel to and from the city a nightmare. With the public transport system in a shambles, work on the Bangalore Metro Rail needs to be speeded up.

For a majority of the seven-million citizens, the controversial Sakrama—a government scheme for regularising illegal sites and buildings by paying a fee—and the capital value system of property tax are a headache. The governor had bought peace by putting these on hold. Though a good monsoon might take care of the contentious Cauvery issue, with load-shedding becoming all too common, BJP will have to move towards generating

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H.D. Revanna. In the Vokkaliga-dominated districts of old Mysore, the party still retains a hold. A great follower of astrologers and godmen, Gowda is said to have rewarded some of them for merely predicting that the son will follow in the father's footsteps to South Block.

It wouldn't have been so far fetched if the Gowda clan's descent into irrelevancy hadn't been such a freefall. Worse, the secular stablemates who helped make the dark horse from Hassan the prime minister in 1996 are now drawing out the knives, accusing Gowda of handing the state to BJP on a platter. Railway Minister Lalu Prasad Yadav was quoted saying: "Gowda ne satyanash kiya (Gowda messed up everything)." The focus will now shift to Kumaraswamy, 47, whose task will be to make sure that JD(S), whose 28 members are most vulnerable to poaching, stays together. That's a tall order but with age on his side and a better temperament than his father, he may yet succeed.

the 10,000 MW of power it had promised in its campaign.

Then there is the pressure of having to rule on the strength of a majority that is wafer-thin. More than the Congress, which will take a while to chart out a credible Opposition policy, or JD(S), which lies helplessly decimated, the threat for Yeddyurappa could come from within, and not necessarily from the Independents. But all that is for the future. For the moment, the teetotaler can afford to party all night long without worrying about a hangover. ■